



A PARTY AT FOOTLOOSE



ABHISHEK AND
VARSHA AGNIHOTRI
FOUNDERS OF FOOTLOOSE

"We can provide a platform, but it is up to the person to come and use that platform the way they want."

lonely and decided to help
nd others like him. Members
le over the age of 45. Most
panions while some find life
Mandakini, 44, a divorcee,
Anand Yatra and found a
. She met her husband at a
rganised by the group and
vo months they were mar-
e were so compatible; we
could share a life," she says.
ose is a club for those over

the age of 28. "The club was formed
late one night in July 2009 after a
friend pointed out that 'I would never
find someone special in my life and
was doomed to a lonely life because
I was in my 30s and still single'," says
Varsha Agnihotri, who founded the
club with her brother Abhishek. He
says: "There is someone for everyone;
sometimes it just takes a while to find
them. We decided to increase our
chances of finding the right person."

HEALTH ✦ HERITAGE

Elsewhere, single parents are cre-
ating groups of their own. The Single
Parents' Association, Mumbai, was
formed by the counsellors of the fam-
ily court due to the rising number of
divorces where children were in-
volved. It provides a platform to sin-
gle parents to discuss issues and
grievances and find solutions to com-
mon problems. Though several peo-
ple are involved with this group, many
prefer to be anonymous as their di-
vorce proceedings are still on.

Psychologists blame the sharp rise
in the number of singles on issues
such as adjustment disorders and
work-related stress that have given
rise to divorces (Mumbai's divorce
rates have gone up by 50 per cent in
the last two years). There has, how-
ever, been a corresponding rise in
singles' groups in the recent past. All
singles' groups believe in one thing—
life is meant to be lived with compan-
ions and you have to take that first
step to find it.

These groups try to provide a com-
fortable ambience for people to min-
gle without being harassed. They do
not tolerate misbehaviour and are
quick to act against those who create
trouble. Varsha says, "If we receive a
complaint against a member, we re-
move that person from the club." Foot-
loose currently operates from the
social networking site Facebook but
they will soon be launching a website.
Most members were invited by their
single friends and the group has
grown through word of mouth. Dev-
asthali, on the other hand, puts
out advertisements in local newspa-
pers. Travel agencies have started or-
ganising tours specifically for single
people. Alope Bajpai, a tour operator
at The Explorers, Mumbai, says many
single people sign up for group tours.
There are a number of websites as
well that organise meets, but one
should use discretion when signing up
to such websites and visit a site that
has been recommended by someone
to avoid any unpleasant experiences.

It's networking in the real world
and it's making a real difference. ■